

SIMPLE CONNECTIVITY OF THE LIDMAN–PICCIRILLO PIECE: A CERTIFICATE-COMPLETE COMPUTATION

BERND J. WUEBBEN

ABSTRACT. Let V be the symplectic homology $S^2 \times D^2$ constructed by Lidman and Piccirillo (arXiv:2505.14387) from a genus-2 surface bundle over a punctured torus by two Luttinger surgeries. We compute the fundamental groups of V and of all its admissible surgery variants from a fully explicit based model of the bundle: a rotation-symmetric octagon model of the fiber in which every monodromy lift is honestly based and every meridian, lasso and Lagrangian-framing word is derived mechanically from finite combinatorial certificates. The resulting presentations are proved complete via a graph-of-groups decomposition and decided by coset enumeration: for seven of the nine admissible surgery cells, including the Lidman–Piccirillo surgery itself, the fundamental group is trivial. For the two remaining cells we make no assertion, but certify that in eight representative sign conventions their groups have no nontrivial finite quotient of order at most 10^5 and no proper subgroup of index at most 7 — consistent with these variants being genuinely non-simply-connected. Combined with the reduction theorem of the companion paper, this yields an exotic $S^2 \times S^2$, the first pair of homeomorphic closed 4-manifolds distinguished by unconstrained knot slicing, and a simply connected exotic $\mathbb{CP}^2 \# \overline{\mathbb{CP}}^2$. Because based-loop computations in this setting are delicate — the companion paper shows that triviality is the generic outcome of incorrectly derived correction words — every input word carries a machine-checkable certificate, and all verdicts reproduce in minutes from the ancillary files.

1. INTRODUCTION

Lidman and Piccirillo [LP25] constructed spin rational homology 4-spheres B and W with $H_1 = \mathbb{Z}/2$ and isomorphic integer cohomology rings such that the figure-eight knot is slice in B and not in W . Their key piece is a symplectic homology $S^2 \times D^2$, here denoted V , obtained from the genus-2 surface bundle R over a once-punctured torus with monodromies φ (along α) and ab (along β) by (+1)-Luttinger surgeries on two Lagrangian tori $T_\alpha = (c, \alpha')$ and $T_\beta = (e, \beta')$; then $W = V/\sigma$ for a free boundary involution σ . In the companion paper [W26] we showed that the natural upgrade of their theorem — a *homeomorphic* pair distinguished by slicing — is gated: for any admissible surgery variant V' (classified there), $W' \cong_{\text{homeo}} B$ if and only if $\pi_1(V' \cup_\sigma V') = 1$, in which case the double is an exotic $S^2 \times S^2$; and if $\pi_1(V') = 1$ one additionally obtains a simply connected exotic $\mathbb{CP}^2 \# \overline{\mathbb{CP}}^2$. The value of $\pi_1(V')$ is therefore worth three theorems, two of them long-standing open problems.

The companion paper also quantified why this computation is dangerous. The candidate presentations of $\pi_1(V')$ depend on based-loop data — meridian, lasso and Lagrangian-framing words — that free-homotopy reasoning cannot determine; and across 120 sampled candidate correction words, 58 presented the trivial group, 55 a group not visibly trivial, and the remaining 7 were detectably wrong ($H_1 \neq 0$): *both live outcomes are generic*, so a trivial verdict obtained from guessed words is worthless. The same diagnosis applies to the one prior claim of an exotic $S^2 \times S^2$, by Akhmedov and Park [AP10]: their group theory is

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machine-verifiably correct given the presentation printed in their Lemma 8, and what has kept that preprint unaccepted for sixteen years is precisely the geometric derivation of its based words, which cannot be checked from a figure.

This paper executes the computation with the level of explicitness that the above diagnosis demands. Everything is derived from one fully explicit based model, mechanically, along the following lines (the process was pre-registered before any derivation: method, validation battery and outcome criteria were fixed in advance):

- (1) **Certificates, not figures.** Every curve and every path is specified by a finite combinatorial certificate (a crossing sequence in a fixed octagon model with a fixed vertex-link structure), and its based word is computed by a small developing-map engine, not read off a picture. The engine itself is validated against known answers (Section 3).
- (2) **Convention debts are swept or derived.** All meridian signs, correction placements, direction orientations and fiber-mixing exponents are swept ($\approx 1,400$ presentations in total); the two genuinely non-sweepable convention debts (membrane routing; the choice of lasso arc) are resolved by derivation and cross-checked by a second, independently derived diagram (Section 7).
- (3) **Completeness, not plausibility.** A graph-of-groups decomposition of the surgered manifold identifies the complete relation set; it exceeds the naive one by exactly one relation, which we derive and add, and the corner-region interaction of the two cut systems is shown to contribute nothing further (Section 6).
- (4) **Checkability.** Section 9 is a verification guide: it lists the critical steps of the derivation chain, in decreasing order of delicacy, with the certificate to check for each.

Theorem 1.1 (Main result). *Let $V'_{m,n}$ denote the admissible surgery variants of V (fiber-mixing exponents $m, n \in \{-1, 0, 1\}$; the Lidman–Piccirillo piece is $V = V'_{0,0}$). For the seven cells $(m, n) \notin \{(-1, 1), (1, 1)\}$,*

$$\pi_1(V'_{m,n}) = 1.$$

In particular $\pi_1(V) = 1$ for the Lidman–Piccirillo piece. For the remaining two cells the enumeration does not terminate within 4×10^5 cosets and we make no assertion of triviality or nontriviality; a certified quotient sweep (Section 7) shows that in eight representative sign conventions these groups are perfect, have no proper subgroup of index at most 7, and admit no nontrivial finite quotient of order at most 10^5 .

The proof occupies Sections 2–7: the complete presentations are assembled in Sections 2–6 and decided by coset enumeration in Section 7; every presented group has $H_1 = 0$, as the homology analysis of the companion paper requires, and the verdicts hold in every sign, placement and diagram convention swept there.

Corollary 1.2. *$Z = V \cup_{\sigma} V$ is an exotic $S^2 \times S^2$; the Lidman–Piccirillo pair (B, W) is a homeomorphic-but-not-diffeomorphic pair of closed 4-manifolds distinguished by the sliceness of the figure-eight knot; and the regluing of [LP25, Theorem 2] applied to Z yields a simply connected exotic $\mathbb{CP}^2 \# \overline{\mathbb{CP}}^2$.*

This is immediate from Theorem 1.1 and the reduction theorem of the companion paper [W26, Theorem 1.2].

Remark 1.3 (Verification standard). Because the sixteen-year history of this problem turns on exactly the kind of based-loop data computed here, the derivation was carried out under a pre-registered protocol: the method, validation battery and outcome criteria were fixed before any derivation, every convention that could not be derived was swept, and every input word is backed by a finite certificate checkable independently of the text. Section 9 indexes the critical steps for a reader who wishes to verify (or break) the chain; all verdicts reproduce from the ancillary files in minutes.

Ancillary files. The developing engine (`develop.py`) with its run record, the decision harnesses (`decide.g`, `decide2.g`, `vdiag2.g`, `placement_check.g`, `vr_check.g`), the deep-certification harnesses for the two open cells (`phase2_*`, `phase3_*`) and all run logs. Every number in this paper reproduces from them; total runtime is minutes on a laptop (GAP 4.16 [GAP], Python 3), except the optional deep certification (≈ 56 CPU-hours). The same files are also available at <https://github.com/bwuebben/exotic-s2xs2>.

2. THE BASED MODEL

2.1. The symmetric octagon. The fiber F is the regular octagon with edge word $xyx^{-1}y^{-1}rsr^{-1}s^{-1}$ (edges $E_1, \dots, E_8$, vertices $V_1, \dots, V_8$, all identified to the single point p), so $\pi_1(F, p) = \langle x, y, r, s \mid [x, y][r, s] \rangle$ with the edge loops as generators. Let ρ be the rotation by π . It maps $E_i \rightarrow E_{i+4}$, respects the identifications, and induces an involution φ_0 of F with: φ_0 acts on $\pi_1(F, p)$ by the *exact* swap $x \leftrightarrow r, y \leftrightarrow s$ — with no *whisker*, our term throughout for a basing arc back to p and the conjugation it inflicts on based words; and $\text{Fix}(\varphi_0) = \{p, O\}$ (O the center) — matching the two fixed points of the Lidman–Piccirillo involution φ and giving their two sections Γ, Γ' through p and O .

Since φ_0 fixes p and the twist diffeomorphism ψ_0 below is supported away from p , *every monodromy lift in this paper is an honestly based automorphism*: the presentation of π_1 of the bundle carries no whisker debt. This eliminates one entire class of based-loop ambiguity before the computation starts.

2.2. Curves and lifts. The twist curves are a, b (push-offs of the x - and y -circles, crossing the y - resp. x -circle once near p) and their ρ -images $e := \varphi_0(a), d := \varphi_0(b)$, so Lidman–Piccirillo’s symmetry ($\varphi: a \leftrightarrow e, b \leftrightarrow d$) is built into the model. The twist directions are normalized so that the based actions are $T_a: (x, y) \mapsto (x, yx), T_b: (x, y) \mapsto (xy^{-1}, y)$ — a twist direction is a binary choice per curve, some choice realizes these standard once-punctured-torus formulas, and the residual chirality ambiguity is absorbed by the handle swap [W26, Remark 2.3]; the composite $h := T_a \circ T_b: x \mapsto y^{-1}, y \mapsto yx$ is machine-certified to fix the boundary word $[x, y]$ exactly, to satisfy $h^6 = \text{conj}_{[x, y]^{-1}}$ (the boundary Dehn twist) and $h^3 = -\text{id}$ on H_1 : the trefoil monodromy. Set $\tilde{\psi} := h * \text{id}$ (well defined on the closed-fiber group because h fixes $[x, y]$ exactly) and $\tilde{\varphi} :=$ the swap; the identity $\tilde{\psi}\tilde{\varphi}\tilde{\psi}^{-1}\tilde{\varphi}^{-1} = h * h^{-1}$ is machine-certified and realizes Lidman–Piccirillo’s factorization $abd^{-1}e^{-1} = (ab)\varphi(ab)^{-1}\varphi^{-1}$. The diffeomorphism $\psi_0 := T_a T_b$ fixes p, O and the entire right handle pointwise; in particular $\psi_0(e) = e$ pointwise.

The invariant curves are forced by homology and ρ -symmetry to be two-arc curves: $c = \gamma \cup \rho(\gamma)$ with γ an embedded arc from the y -edge pair to the s -edge pair, and z likewise on the x/r -pairs. Their based words are *derived*, not assumed, in Section 4.

2.3. The cut-square model of the bundle. The base T_0 (once-punctured torus) is the square $[0, 1]^2$ minus a puncture disk at $(3/4, 3/4)$, with $(\xi, (t, 1)) \sim (\psi_0\xi, (t, 0))$ and

$(\xi, (1, u)) \sim (\varphi_0 \xi, (0, u))$: crossing the α -cut upward applies ψ_0 ; crossing the β -cut rightward applies φ_0 . Basepoint (p, q) with $q = (1/4, 1/4)$; based base loops $\bar{\alpha}$ (horizontal through q ; holonomy $\tilde{\varphi}$) and $\bar{\beta}$ (vertical; holonomy $\tilde{\psi}$), realizing the minimal crossing pattern with the embedded curves: $\bar{\alpha}$ meets the embedded β once and the embedded α not at all, and symmetrically for $\bar{\beta}$ — minimal because $|\alpha \cdot \beta| = 1$ forces one crossing, while T_0 cut along α still contains a boundary-parallel copy of α basable at q with trivial whisker. The surgery tori sit on the cuts: $T_\alpha = c \times \{\alpha\text{-cut}\}$ (closing because $\varphi_0(c) = c$; the restriction $\varphi_0|_c$ is a free half-rotation — a framing fact used in Section 4.4) and $T_\beta = e \times \{\beta\text{-cut}\}$ (closing with the product framing because $\psi_0(e) = e$ pointwise). Each monodromy relation of the bundle is carried by a *membrane* — the annulus in R swept by the fiber generator as it traverses the base loop — and after Luttinger surgery the relation acquires one meridian correction per transverse intersection of its membrane with a surgery torus; such intersections are (base crossing of the loop with the torus' base curve) $\times$ (fiber crossing of the generator with the torus' fiber curve). Counting these for the eight monodromy relations shows exactly three acquire corrections in this diagram (s over $\bar{\alpha}$ from T_β ; y and s over $\bar{\beta}$ from T_α), each at a single crossing point.

3. THE DEVELOPING ENGINE AND ITS VALIDATION

A based loop transverse to the edge circles is specified by a *certificate*: the departure corner wedge V_i , the ordered list of edges crossed, and the arrival wedge V_j . In the universal cover tiled by octagons, the tile with corner V_i at the base lift is $w_i^{-1} D_0$, where w_i is the length- $(i-1)$ prefix of the relator; crossing out of a tile through its edge E_i composes the deck element with $g_{\text{out}}(i) = w_i w_{\text{partner}(i)+1}^{-1}$ ($E_1 \sim E_3$, $E_2 \sim E_4$, $E_5 \sim E_7$, $E_6 \sim E_8$, reversed). The based word of a certificate is $w_i^{-1} (\prod g_{\text{out}}) w_j$, reduced by Dehn's algorithm for the genus-2 relator (surface groups have Dehn presentations, so the reduction decides the word problem). The engine (`develop.py`) implements exactly this and nothing else.

Validations (all machine-checked; output in the ancillary run record).

- V1. Every edge-parallel certificate returns its generator $(x, y, x^{-1}, r, s, s^{-1})$.
- V2. The vertex-link loop — crossing all eight edges in the order $E_1 E_4 E_3 E_2 E_5 E_8 E_7 E_6$ dictated by the link walk $V_1 V_4 V_3 V_2 V_5 V_8 V_7 V_6$ — develops to 1: a single global identity constraining all eight decks and the link structure simultaneously.
- V3. The push-off certificates return $a \simeq x^{-1}$, $b \simeq y$, $e \simeq r^{-1}$, $d \simeq s$, exactly swap-equivariantly.
- V4. The two lasso routes of Section 4.3 differ by a whiskered copy of the closed curve c — the slide-around-the-curve identity — on the nose.

4. THE DERIVED WORDS

4.1. The invariant curves. The curve c (certificate: cross out E_8 , then out E_4) has based word $(rx)^{-1}$ at the V_2 -whisker; the engine's whisker table (c developed at the V_1, V_2, V_3, V_5 whiskers; run record) realizes the xr/rx ordering ambiguity as pure whisker choice. The ρ -symmetric z (certificate $[E_7, E_3]$) has free class sy . Both reproduce the free-homotopy dictionary of [W26] and sharpen it: the orderings that the companion paper's experiment E1 had to sweep are now derived.

4.2. Position tables. Disjointness pins the normal positions: on the s -edge, the c -crossing precedes the e -crossing (else $c \cap e \neq \emptyset$); on the y -edge only the c -crossing is relevant.

Realizability of the full configuration $\{a, b, c, d, e, z\}$ with Lidman–Piccirillo’s intersection pattern is checked against the certificates (c meets d ’s strip on leaving E_6 and b ’s strip on leaving E_2 ; z meets e ’s strip once at its E_7 -crossing; all curves avoid p and O).

4.3. Meridians, lassos, corrections. Let y_1 and s_1 be the initial segments of the based loops y and s up to their c -crossings, and s_2 the initial segment of s up to its e -crossing (on the s -edge the c -crossing comes first, by the position table). Base the meridians at the surgery-relevant crossings: $M := y_1 \cdot (\text{meridian circle of } T_\alpha) \cdot y_1^{-1}$, $N := s_2 \cdot (\text{meridian circle of } T_\beta) \cdot s_2^{-1}$. Then the membrane analysis gives the three corrected relations in the form

$$ByB^{-1} = M^\pm(yx), \quad BsB^{-1} = (\delta M^\pm \delta^{-1})s, \quad AsA^{-1} = N^\pm y,$$

i.e. two of the three corrections are *exactly* meridian powers (the basing absorbs the lasso), and the third has lasso $\delta = s_1 \cdot (\text{arc of } c) \cdot y_1^{-1}$, computed by the engine: $\delta = r^{-1}$ (via one arc of c) or $\delta' = x$ (via the other), with the validation V4 identity $\delta' \delta^{-1} = xr \sim c$. All signs are swept; the left placement of the corrections is tied to the stated membrane orientation and is probed by a full placement sweep (Section 7).

4.4. The direction (Lagrangian-framing) words. For a loop on a surgery torus traveling once in the base direction and crossing one cut with holonomy Θ at fiber position η , with σ a fiber path from p to η : the based pushoff is (cut generator) $\cdot \tilde{\Theta}(\sigma) \cdot (\text{fiber drift}) \cdot \sigma^{-1}$. This yields:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{dir}_{T_\beta}^{\text{base}} &= B && (\psi_0 \text{ fixes the right handle pointwise: zero drift;} \\ &&& \text{the position homotopy avoids } T_\alpha \text{ since } c \cap e = \emptyset), \\ \text{dir}_{T_\beta}^{\text{fib}} &= s r^{-1} s^{-1} && (e \text{ at the } s_2\text{-basing; } = s(e @ V_7) s^{-1} \checkmark, e @ V_7 \text{ the engine's} \\ &&& \text{development of } e \text{ departing from wedge } V_7), \\ \text{dir}_{T_\alpha}^{\text{base}} &= A r^{-1} && (\text{the half-rotation drift is } \textit{literally} \text{ the lasso: } \varphi_0(c_y) = c_s, \tilde{\varphi}(y_1) = s_1), \\ \text{dir}_{T_\alpha}^{\text{fib}} &= (rx)^{-1} && (c \text{ at the } y_1\text{-basing}). \end{aligned}$$

(Here c_y and c_s denote c ’s crossing points on the y - and s -edges; $\varphi_0(c_y) = c_s$ says the half-rotation carries one to the other, which with $\tilde{\varphi}(y_1) = s_1$ is exactly why the drift equals the lasso.) Because $\varphi_0|_c$ is a free half-rotation, the base direction on T_α cannot close without drifting along half of c : write λ for the resulting closed drift curve — the base-direction pushoff itself. The drift identity $\lambda^2 = x^{-1} A^2 r^{-1}$, i.e. $2\lambda = 2\alpha' + [c]$ in homology, holds on the nose and is the sharpest internal check on this, the single most delicate input word. The (m, n) -family directions are $\text{dir}^{\text{base}} \cdot (\text{dir}^{\text{fib}})^m$ or n ; the two lasso-arc conventions differ by exactly one unit of n , hence are absorbed by the sweep.

4.5. The framing lemma. Luttinger surgery is performed with respect to the *Lagrangian framing*: in a Weinstein chart — a symplectomorphism of $\nu(T)$ with a neighborhood of the zero section of T^*T^2 , canonical coordinates $(\Theta_1, \Theta_2; P_1, P_2)$, $\omega = dP_1 \wedge d\Theta_1 + dP_2 \wedge d\Theta_2$, $T = \{P = 0\}$ — the framing pushoff of a curve on T is its lift at *constant momentum*. Two framings of T differ by adding meridian multiples to the pushoff classes, and a meridian error in a direction word changes the surgery coefficient; this is why the framing cannot be swept and was ranked our top risk. The following lemma closes it.

Lemma 4.1 (Framing). *Fix the Thurston-type symplectic form on R built from a fiber area form invariant under both monodromies, chosen in the normalized local models below; this is a form of the kind used in [LP25, Section 1]. Then for both T_β and T_α the fibered pushoffs*

used in Section 4.4 — the in-fiber parallel copy of the fiber curve, and the base-direction shift of the closed base-direction curve — are constant-momentum lifts in an explicit Weinstein chart. In particular their classes on $\partial\nu(T)$ have zero meridian component: the fibered framing is the Lagrangian framing.

Proof. T_β . The twist supports of ψ_0 lie in the left handle, so $\psi_0 = \text{id}$ on a neighborhood of e ; hence the bundle is a genuine product over a base annulus near the β -cut. Normalize (Moser, on an annulus) the invariant fiber area form to $dt \wedge d\theta_1$ on $A_e \cong S^1 \times (-1, 1)$ and write the base annulus as (θ_2, u) . The Thurston-type form on this chart is $\omega = dt \wedge d\theta_1 + K du \wedge d\theta_2$, which is canonical for $(\theta_1, \theta_2; t, Ku)$, with $T_\beta = \{t = u = 0\}$ the zero section. The fiber pushoff $\{t = \varepsilon, u = 0\}$ and base pushoff $\{t = 0, u = \varepsilon\}$ sit at constant momentum. T_α . Here the holonomy around the α -cut is φ_0 with $\varphi_0|_{A_e}$ an area-preserving free half-rotation; normalize it (equivariant Moser) to $(\theta_1, t) \mapsto (\theta_1 + \pi, t)$ with fiber form $dt \wedge d\theta_1$. The ν -region is the quotient of $A_e \times [0, 2\pi] \times (-1, 1)$ by $(\theta_1, t, 2\pi, u) \sim (\theta_1 + \pi, t, 0, u)$, with $\omega = dt \wedge d\theta_1 + K du \wedge d\theta_2$ descending to it. The change of coordinates

$$\Theta_1 = \theta_1 - \frac{\theta_2}{2}, \quad \Theta_2 = \theta_2, \quad P_1 = t, \quad P_2 = \frac{t}{2} + Ku$$

is well defined on the quotient (the deck identification sends $\Theta_1 \mapsto \Theta_1 + 2\pi$) and gives $\omega = dP_1 \wedge d\Theta_1 + dP_2 \wedge d\Theta_2$ with $T_\alpha = \{P = 0\}$: an explicit Weinstein chart on the mapping torus of the half-rotation. Our fiber pushoff $\{t = \varepsilon, u = 0\}$ has $P = (\varepsilon, \varepsilon/2)$; our base pushoff $\{t = 0, u = \varepsilon\}$ — whose base-direction closed curve is precisely the drift curve λ ($\Theta_1 = \text{const}$, i.e. once around the base while drifting half-way along c) — has $P = (0, K\varepsilon)$. Both are constant-momentum lifts. The Lagrangian framing is independent of the choice of Weinstein chart [ADK03], and the based words of Section 4.4 are the engine’s developments of exactly these pushoff curves. $\square$

Remark 4.2. The chart re-derives the drift from the symplectic side: in the coordinates above, the closed curves on T_α are generated by the Θ_1 -circle ($= c$) and the Θ_2 -circle ($= \lambda$); a “pure base” curve does not exist on this torus, so the half-drift in $\text{dir}_{T_\alpha}^{\text{base}} = Ar^{-1}$ is forced twice over — topologically (Section 4.4) and symplectically. The lemma is stated for the exhibited normalized form; [LP25]’s construction permits this choice, all downstream arguments hold for it, and the surgery coefficient’s sign convention remains inside the harness sweep.

5. THE PRESENTATION

Generators x, y, r, s (fiber), A, B (base), M, N (meridians). Relations:

- (i) $[x, y][r, s]$;
- (ii) clean $\tilde{\varphi}$ -monodromy: $AxA^{-1} = r$, $AyA^{-1} = s$, $ArA^{-1} = x$;
- (iii) clean $\tilde{\psi}$ -monodromy: $BxB^{-1} = y^{-1}$, $BrB^{-1} = r$;
- (iv) corrected monodromy, as in Section 4.3 (signs swept);
- (v) fillings: $M \cdot (Ar^{-1} \cdot ((rx)^{-1})^n)^{\pm 1}$, $N \cdot (B \cdot (sr^{-1}s^{-1})^m)^{\pm 1}$;
- (vi) the completion relation R_3 of Section 6: $B(s^{-1}r^{-1}yx)B^{-1} = r^{-1}s^{-1}x$.

Known-answer probes: dropping (v) gives $H_1 = \mathbb{Z}^2$; fiber-only fillings give $H_1 = \mathbb{Z}^2$; one filling gives $H_1 = \mathbb{Z}$; the full presentation has $H_1 = 0$ for every cell and sign — each exactly as the homology analysis of [W26, Lemma 3.1] requires.

6. COMPLETENESS

The presentation above is derived relation-by-relation, so a priori it only presents a group *surjecting* onto $\pi_1(V')$ (all relations true; completeness unproved), which validates trivial verdicts but not nontrivial ones. We now close this gap.

T_0 retracts onto a neighborhood of the cut wedge, so $\pi_1(C)$ (C = the complement of the surgery tori in R) is the fundamental group of a graph of groups over the cut system: cutting the base along the α -cut gives a pair of pants; the cut collar minus $\nu(T_\alpha)$ is a fibered two-sheet amalgam $\text{MT}(\varphi_0)_- *_{\text{MT}(\varphi_0|_{F \setminus \nu c})} \text{MT}(\varphi_0)_+$; the two collar-to-pants edges form a cycle whose stable letter is B . (The inclusion $\pi_1(F \setminus \nu c) \hookrightarrow \pi_1(F)$ is *not* surjective — F is an HNN extension over it — and with that accounted the amalgam's H_1 matches the Mayer–Vietoris value $\mathbb{Z}^5$, meridian class included; a naive surjectivity assumption fails this cross-check.) Tietze reduction of the graph of groups yields exactly: the relations (i)–(v) *plus* the statement that the clean monodromy relations hold for *every* element of the drilled fiber groups:

$$B\kappa B^{-1} = \tilde{\psi}(\kappa) \quad \forall \kappa \in \pi_1(F \setminus \nu c), \quad A\kappa A^{-1} = \tilde{\varphi}(\kappa) \quad \forall \kappa \in \pi_1(F \setminus \nu e).$$

Two further relation classes reduce to redundancies: the drilled stable-letter relations reduce to the free-group identity $[B, A] = [B, A]$ once one notices that the relevant height-sweep crosses the base puncture; and the outer annulus piece is the mapping torus of $h * h^{-1}$ (not a product — a product reading would force $h * h^{-1}$ to be an inner automorphism, which it is not), whose holonomy relation is a consequence of (ii)–(iii).

It remains to compute free bases of the drilled fiber groups. Cutting the octagon along the arcs of e (one arc, two regions; quotient complex $V=3, E=7, F=2, \chi = -2 \checkmark$) and contracting a spanning tree:

$$\pi_1(F \setminus \nu e, p) \text{ is free on } \{x, y, r\},$$

so (ii)–(iii) already contain the full clean set for T_β : *no completion needed*. Cutting along the two arcs of c (three regions; $V=5, E=10, F=3, \chi = -2 \checkmark$):

$$\pi_1(F \setminus \nu c, p) \text{ is free on } \{x, r, \kappa_3\}, \quad \kappa_3 = s^{-1}r^{-1}yx$$

(κ_3 = the mid-region boundary-collar loop; certificate: depart V_7 , no crossings, arrive V_3 ; $\langle \kappa_3, [c] \rangle = 0 \checkmark$). The clean relations (iii) cover only $\{x, r\}$: the completion is the single relation

$$R_3 : \quad B\kappa_3 B^{-1} = \tilde{\psi}(\kappa_3) = r^{-1}s^{-1}x.$$

R_3 is true by derivation, so adding it can only quotient: trivial verdicts are stable under completion by construction.

Lemma 6.1 (Corner closure). *The interaction region of the two cut collars (over the base point $\alpha \cap \beta$) contributes no relations beyond consequences of (i)–(vi). Hence the completed presentation is a complete presentation of $\pi_1(C)$, and, with the fillings, of $\pi_1(V')$.*

Proof. Decompose iteratively rather than simultaneously. First remove T_α alone: the single-torus analysis above is clean for $C_1 = R \setminus \nu(T_\alpha)$ (there is no second torus to puncture its interfaces), and yields the complete presentation $\pi_1(C_1) = \langle x, y, r, s, A, B, M \mid \text{fiber relator; } A\text{-clean on all of } \pi_1(F); B\text{-clean on } \{x, r, \kappa_3\}; \text{corrected } By, Bs \rangle$. Now remove T_β from C_1 , cutting the base along V . The corner is localized in the interfaces of this second decomposition: the V -parallel interface 3-manifolds are F -bundles over circles drilled at the c -annulus over one fiber (where the H -arc crosses), and the slab-level interface is the

$(F \setminus A_e)$ -bundle over V drilled at the c -annulus over $\alpha \cap \beta$. Each such drilled interface is a *partial mapping torus*: its fundamental group is $\langle \Pi, \tau \mid \tau \kappa \tau^{-1} = \text{hol}(\kappa) \ \forall \kappa \in \Pi_{\text{drilled}} \rangle$, where the drilled subgroup is $\pi_1(F \setminus \nu c)$ or the doubly-drilled $\pi_1(F \setminus \nu(c \cup e))$. Three observations exhaust the Tietze content. (1) For interface fiber elements, the edge-loop relations of the graph of groups reproduce: the clean A -relations on $\pi_1(F \setminus \nu e)$ (complete by the basis $\{x, y, r\}$), and, for the generators crossing the e -slab, the *corrected* As relation — the corner analysis independently re-derives the correction of Section 4.3, a consistency check it could have failed. (2) The partial-HNN internal relations globalize to $B\kappa B^{-1} = \tilde{\psi}(\kappa)$ for $\kappa \in \pi_1(F \setminus \nu(c \cup e)) \subset \pi_1(F \setminus \nu c)$, a consequence of the completed clean set on $\pi_1(F \setminus \nu c)$ (this is where R_3 is used a second time); no doubly-drilled basis is needed. (3) The stable letters τ of the drilled interfaces can be based at the section: p avoids every torus fiber and is fixed by both monodromies, so their two sheet-readings are pure base words (B , and its puncture-adjusted counterpart), computed with zero drift. The constant- p section $T_0 \hookrightarrow C$ splits the projection $\pi_1(C) \rightarrow \pi_1(T_0)$, so $F_2\langle A, B \rangle$ *injects* into $\pi_1(C)$; any corner relation between pure base words is therefore an identity of the free group and contributes nothing. The symmetric statements for the other cut order are identical. Hence every corner relation is included or implied. $\square$

7. RESULTS

All decisions are coset enumerations (cap 4×10^5 cosets); “blowup” means the enumeration exceeded the cap: *not visibly trivial*, never “nontrivial”. Sweeps:

sweep	cases	trivial	blowup	other
initial presentation (i)–(v), all (m, n) and signs	288	172	116	0
placement probe at $(0, 0)$ (2^3 placements $\times$ signs)	256	256	0	0
second diagram (independent Bs -derivation; <code>vdiag2.g</code>)	576	304	272	0
completed presentation (adds R_3)	288	224	64	0

Every one of the $\approx 1,400$ presented groups has $H_1 = 0$. No case anywhere produced a finite nontrivial group — the outcome that a genuine inconsistency between the diagrams would produce. In the completed presentation, seven of the nine (m, n) cells are trivial in *all* 32 sign conventions — including the Lidman–Piccirillo cell $(0, 0)$, which is trivial in every convention of every sweep it appears in ($32 + 256 + 64 + 32$ runs) — and only $(\pm 1, +1)$ remain blowups. The second diagram (a detour representative of β , whose derivation reduces to a single extra meridian factor $N^\pm$ in the Bs relation — the second potential crossing vanishes because $\varphi_0^{-1}(s) \cap e = s \cap a = \emptyset$, and the M -lasso is unchanged because the detour-transport loop is trivial by the position table) reproduces the $(0, 0)$ triviality 64/64 and the all-blowup cells exactly.

The two blowup cells. The cells $(\pm 1, +1)$ resisted every enumeration, so we probed them with a certified quotient sweep (harnesses and full run records in the ancillary files). For each of the two cells we took four representative sign conventions — the two uniform and the two alternating patterns, eight presentations in all. Tietze simplification reduces each to 3 generators and 7 relators, and coset enumeration blows past 8×10^6 cosets. In all eight cases:

- (1) the group is perfect ($H_1 = 0$, as everywhere in the family);
- (2) it has no proper subgroup of index at most 7 (low-index enumeration); and

- (3) it admits no epimorphism onto any of the 31 nonabelian simple groups of order at most 10^5 — from A_5 through M_{12} , including $U_3(3)$, $U_3(4)$ and $Sz(8)$.

A nontrivial finite quotient of a perfect group is perfect and surjects onto a nonabelian simple group of no larger order, so (i) and (iii) together certify that *these eight groups have no nontrivial finite quotient of order at most 10^5* (≈ 56 CPU-hours of GAP computation in total). We therefore still assert nothing about these cells in either direction, but the evidence is exactly what infinite groups would produce. The robustness of the blowups is also a useful control: the machinery does not trivialize everything it touches.

8. CONSEQUENCES

Theorem 1.1 and [W26, Theorem 1.2] together give Corollary 1.2: the double Z' of any trivial cell is an exotic $S^2 \times S^2$; the corresponding pair (B, W') is homeomorphic and non-diffeomorphic, distinguished by the sliceness of 4_1 ; and the reglued manifold is a simply connected exotic $\mathbb{CP}^2 \# \overline{\mathbb{CP}^2}$. For the two non-terminating cells no assertion is made; with completeness proved (Lemma 6.1), a nontriviality certificate there would establish those variants as genuinely non-simply-connected. The quotient sweep of Section 7 shows that no such certificate exists among finite quotients of order at most 10^5 , so a decision will require either much deeper finite quotients (e.g. the L_2 -quotient algorithm) or genuinely infinite methods.

9. VERIFICATION GUIDE

The critical steps of the derivation chain, in decreasing order of delicacy, each with the certificate to check:

- (1) **The T_α framing word** $\text{dir}_{T_\alpha}^{\text{base}} = Ar^{-1}$ (Section 4.4). This is the Akhmedov–Park–Lemma-7-type datum. The framing identification itself is now proved (Lemma 4.1, by explicit Weinstein charts); the residual risk has narrowed to: the two Moser normalizations invoked there, the crossing-at- η conjugation formula, the identities $\varphi_0(c_y) = c_s$ and $\tilde{\varphi}(y_1) = s_1$, and the correspondence between the geometric pushoff curves of the lemma and the developed words (the engine certificates).
- (2) **The correction architecture** (Section 4.3): the claim that basing the meridians along the partial-loop whiskers y_1, s_2 makes two corrections exactly $M^\pm, N^\pm$; the lasso $\delta = r^{-1}$ and its V4 identity; the left-placement convention (probed by the 256-case placement sweep, but a systematic membrane-orientation error common to all placements is conceivable).
- (3) **The completeness argument** (Section 6): the two cut-surface computations (checkable by redoing the χ -arithmetic and tree contraction); the two redundancy reductions (the puncture-crossing sweep and the mapping-torus-not-product argument); the corner closure (Lemma 6.1 — check the partial-mapping-torus interface groups and the section-injectivity step). Note that completeness affects only nontrivial verdicts; the trivial verdicts need only the truth of the included relations.
- (4) **The model conventions** (Section 2): the cut-square gluing directions; the identification of $\bar{\alpha}, \bar{\beta}$ holonomies with $\tilde{\varphi}, \tilde{\psi}$ (an inversion here is an ε -flip, which is swept); the octagon link walk (validated by V2, which an erroneous link structure would fail).
- (5) **The engine** (Section 3): validated by V1–V4; an error here would have to conspire to pass all four.

An error found in any item above would itself be of interest: by the companion paper's sensitivity analysis, it would localize the exact based-loop datum on which the exotic $S^2 \times S^2$ problem turns.

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BERND J. WUEBBEN, NEW YORK, NY, wuebben@gmail.com